Cuba, the CIA Director was convinced he would. When Soviet S-75 SAMs were photographed by a CIA U-2 at the end of August, McCone expressed his concerns. 'They're not putting them in to protect the cane cutters. They're putting them in to blind our reconnaissance eye.'[82] He told Maxwell Taylor and his colleagues that 'I had to put myself in Khrushchev's shoes … If I were Khrushchev, I would put MRBMs in Cuba.'[83] His analysts might have told him that 'mirror imaging' in intelligence analysis was fraught with difficulties. They might have also pointed out flaws in his logic. Soviet SAMs had previously been supplied to countries like Egypt and Indonesia, where there were no Soviet nuclear weapons. Indeed, as Fursenko and Naftali have shown, initial deployment of the surface-to-air missiles was decided prior to Operation Anadyr.[84] And when the MRBMs were withdrawn, some SAMs stayed behind (leading McCone to worry that some MRBMs also might remain).

Having told the President that Moscow was putting nuclear missiles in Cuba – which would mean a major confrontation between Washington and Moscow – the Director of the Central Intelligence Agency took an important decision. He went off to the south of France for a month. He was away on honeymoon from 23 August to 23 September. McCone did travel up to the US embassy in Paris to communicate his concerns to his deputy, General Marshal Carter. He was nevertheless sunning himself on the French Riviera when the CIA was producing its mistaken intelligence assessment for the President.

Furthermore, McCone was unaware that U-2 overflights had been drastically curtailed since 5 September.[85] He was not happy to learn this news on his return. In September a U-2 flown by a Nationalist Chinese pilot was shot down over mainland China. Rusk and Bundy were concerned to prevent a similar incident over Cuba. In May 1960 the loss of a CIA U-2 over the USSR (flown by Gary Powers) had massive diplomatic consequences and led to the abandonment of a four-power summit in Paris that had taken years to prepare. The Secretary of State, in particular, was anxious that an incident over Cuba would complicate US diplomacy on Berlin. On McCone's return, however, the decision was reversed, and direct overflights mounted once weather permitted. At the same time,